Visualization & the Humanities - Bridging Communities, Building Practices

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Visualization is an increasingly vital aspect of digital humanities (DH) research, serving as a tool for ideation, exploration and analysis, but also as a major medium for communication, thus making data and research more accessible to various audiences (Benito-Santos / Theron 2020). For many DH projects, the question is no longer *whether* to visualize data, but rather *how* to do so effectively and consciously with regard to various methodological and epistemological tradeoffs.

The VIS4DH community, founded in 2016, has emerged as a forum for such questions and fostered a multifaceted discourse around the unique needs of visualizing humanities data (Bradley et al. 2019, Drucker et al. 2023). While aiming for a bilateral exchange at the intersection of visualization and the digital humanities, the VIS4DH workshop (https://vis4dh.org) has been tied to the IEEE VIS community so far ( ), which fostered attendance and exchanges from computer science-centered actors and points of view. As a 'trading zone' (Fickers / Heijden 2020) this forum aims for inclusion and access, but so far, its main affiliation also limited access to emerging practices, tools, and critical discussions for relevant communities convening elsewhere (e.g., Jänicke 2016). To that end, members of the VIS4DH consortium held a workshop at DH 2023 (Hinrichs et al. 2023) which focused on visualization literacy, challenges and research opportunities for humanities data visualization. The event ran at full capacity, and participants expressed their enthusiasm, showcasing the relevance of providing opportunities and platforms to discuss and showcase visualization research and practice in the context of DH scholarship.

Building on that effort, we aim to organize an "unconference" at the DH conference 2025 to consolidate and deepen the discourse around visualization and the humanities on the ADHO side. As members of the VIS4DH consortium, we aim to create an inclusive, participant-driven space where DH researchers can not only learn about visualization research, but also actively discuss a research agenda at the intersection of visualization and DH, mapping out their own interests and requirements. The unconference format, which prioritizes collaboration and responsiveness to participants' interests, is particularly suited to fostering interdisciplinary exchange. Participants will bring their own questions, challenges, and topics related to visualization in DH, which will form the basis for discussions and collaborative ideation throughout the day, while the organizers will bring in their expertise to develop research questions, projects, methods, communities, and further debates in the field (Bludau et al. 2020, Drucker et al. 2023, Grandjean 2024, Hinrichs et al. 2019, Jacomy 2020, Lamqaddam et al. 2020, Windhager et al. 2024).

Goals & Objectives

This unconference will serve three key purposes:

1. *Community Introduction*: It will provide an accessible entry point for DH practitioners to engage with actors of the VIS4DH community, its ongoing discussions, and resources.
2. *Participant-Driven Dialogue*: Attendees will guide the event's focus, ensuring relevance to

their needs and fostering grassroots contributions to the discourse on DH visualization.

3. *Strategic Development*: The event aims to document open questions and future challenges and thus lay the groundwork for future exchanges at DH conferences, creating a sustainable foundation for ongoing collaboration. This will include a discussion of the option to form an ADHO Special Interest Group.

Format

We propose an unconference format for this workshop to enable participant-driven activities and discussions. As workshop organizers, we will act as facilitators to ensure productive conversations and workshop outcomes. Consequently, the participating members will decide the exact format of activities during the event itself. However, we put forward a number of suggested activities below to serve as inspiration and trigger discussion.

Pre-workshop activities

- Submit activities (including tutorials) and topics to discuss
- Participants fill out a questionnaire profiling their background, work and interest that we can then use to structure discussions at the workshop (and create personalized buttons or physicalizations to facilitate networking).

Suggested activities at the workshop

- Pecha Kucha / Ignite talks
- Tea for two
- Brief hands-on tutorials (options include inputs on selected visualization idioms, visualization & ideation, participative design approaches, complexity transformations, scalable reading & viewing, collection visualization, uncertainty visualization, generous interface design, AI & visualization, critical design strategies, or grounding visualization and evaluation design in humanities scholarship)
- Demos & Design critiques
- Lab presentations (similar to the Labtalks at VIS4DH: https://vis4dh.dbvis.de/2022/labtalks/)

By taking this bottom-up approach, the unconference format can catalyze a community of practice around visualization in DH, ensuring that it reflects the diverse perspectives, questions, and expertise of its members. This inaugural event represents an opportunity to create lasting connections, surface emerging trends, and inspire innovative practices in DH visualization.

We invite DH researchers, educators, and practitioners—whether seasoned visualization experts or newcomers curious about its potential—to join us for this participatory event. Together, we will chart pathways for integrating cutting-edge visualization approaches into DH while ensuring that our practices are grounded in the values and priorities of the field.

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